Haoran Sun

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Indefinite leave to remain (UK). No visa sponsorship required.

Research Profile

My research examines how public policy, finance and market structure shape firm innovation, productivity and growth, using applied microeconometrics on UK firm-level microdata and game-theoretic modelling.

Fields: Industrial policy, policy evaluation and regional economics.

Job Market Paper

Revisiting Strategic Protectionism in Network Markets
Nigar Hashimzade and Haoran Sun
Submitted to the Canadian Journal of Economics. CESifo Working Paper No. 12592 (2026). arXiv:2603.29542
Studies industrial policy in a two-country model with strategic trade and R&D under network externalities. Shows that policy competition can generate a win-win welfare outcome, depending on the strength of network effects, the degree of product differentiation, and whether innovation is product- or process-based.

Employment

2025– **Researcher (PDRA)**, Durham University Business School
Smart & Scale Up project, in partnership with RTC North
Research on regional scaleup dynamics in North East England using UK firm-level microdata. Run the project's econometric analysis. Produced the research report for RTC North.

2023–2025 **Research Fellow**, University of St Andrews
ESRC-funded project (ES/W010259/1) on SME finance, investment and productivity
Led the econometric analysis across the project's work packages and co-authored five papers in two years, three now published.

Education

2017–2024 **PhD in Economics**, Durham University
ESRC-funded studentship: Tax Incentives for Innovation
Thesis: The Economics of Innovation, Investment, and Taxation

2018 **Visiting PhD student**, University of Exeter

2015–2017 **MSc in Economics** (Distinction), Durham University

2012–2015 **BA in Economics** (2:1 Honours), Durham University

Publications

Spatial Myopia, Financial Hubs and the "Golden Triangle": Tracing the Uneven Landscape of International Equity Investments in the UK
Ross Brown, Augusto Rocha, Haoran Sun, Marc Cowling
British Journal of Management (ABS 4), 2026

Why Owls Fly While Ostriches Flounder: An Empirical Study of Advice Takers and Non-Advice Takers
Ross Brown, Marc Cowling, Weixi Liu, Xinlun Song, Haoran Sun
Journal of Small Business Management (ABS 3), 2026

Unpacking the Money-Distance Nexus: Mapping the Spatial Configuration of Exogenous Entrepreneurial Finance across UK Entrepreneurial Ecosystems
Ross Brown, Augusto Rocha, Haoran Sun, Marc Cowling
Small Business Economics (ABS 3), 2025

Papers Under Review

Can We See it in the Numbers Yet? Artificial Intelligence, Firm-Level Productivity and SMEs
Ross Brown, Haoran Sun, Marc Cowling, David Dowell
Journal of Technology Transfer, revise and resubmit

Does it Pay to be a Good Listener? The Impact of "Guided Preparation" on Innovation and Productivity in UK SMEs
Ross Brown, Haoran Sun, Weixi Liu, Marc Cowling, Xinlun Song
Technological Forecasting and Social Change, under review

Papers in Preparation

The Effect of Direct and Indirect Support for Innovation on Productivity: Evidence from Young UK Businesses
John Moffat, Haoran Sun
Drafting for submission

Understanding Regional Differences in the Incidence of High-Growth Firms: Firm-Level Evidence on the North East of England
John Moffat, Haoran Sun
Drafting for submission

Finance, Growth and Productivity in Family-Owned SMEs
Ross Brown, Marc Cowling, Haoran Sun
Drafting for submission

Do Science Parks Act as a Magnet for Investment? The Role of University Proximity
Ross Brown, Marc Cowling, Haoran Sun
Analysis in progress

Policy Reports

Advice and SMEs: Who Takes it and What Happens Thereafter?
Ross Brown, Marc Cowling, Haoran Sun
Enterprise Research Centre, ERC Research Paper No. 112, 2024

Grants

2026 **ERC–DBT Small Grant Funding**: "A Study of Finance, Growth and Productivity in Family-Owned SMEs", £5,000
Ross Brown, Marc Cowling, Haoran Sun (Co-Investigator)

2024 **ERC–DBT Small Grant Funding**: "Advice and SMEs: Who Takes it and What Happens Thereafter?", £5,000
Ross Brown, Marc Cowling, Haoran Sun (Co-Investigator)

Teaching

2026–27	Stata sessions, Dissertation in Economics (UG)	Durham University
2026	Guest lectures, Platform Economics (PG)	Newcastle University
2020	Teaching Assistant, Macroeconomics (UG)	Durham University
2019	Teaching Assistant, Corporate Finance (UG)	Durham University

Teaching interests: Microeconomics, Macroeconomics, Econometrics, Microeconometrics, and Public Economics (UG and PG).

Teaching development: Working towards Advance HE Fellowship. DCAD Teaching Skills workshops on seminars, tutorials and laboratory teaching (October 2026), with an Associate Fellowship application planned for 2027.

Presentations and Engagement

2025	North East High Growth Business report, presented to RTC North (findings informed its advisory targeting)	
2025	ERC–DBT Longitudinal Small Business Survey Dissemination Event	London
2024	ZEW Competition and Innovation (CISS 2024)	Ulcinj, Montenegro
2024	"Unpacking the Money-Distance Nexus", Internal Research Seminar	University of St Andrews

Honours and Professional Activities

2026–	Member, Royal Economic Society
2026–	Member, British Academy Early Career Researcher Network
2017–2022	NINE Doctoral Training Partnership Studentship, ESRC
2017–2021	Research Training Support Grant, ESRC

Data Expertise

ONS Accredited Researcher (2019–). UK firm-level microdata: Business Structure Database, Annual Business Survey, UK Innovation Survey and Business Enterprise Research and Development survey, Longitudinal Small Business Survey, and Crunchbase.

Technical Skills and Languages

Software: Stata, R, Python, MATLAB, Maple, LaTeX
English: Professional proficiency **Mandarin**: Native proficiency

References

Prof. John Moffat
Department of Economics
Durham University Business School
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Department of Economics, Finance and Accounting
Brunel University of London
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